

How Should We Evaluate the Democratic Socialists of America (DSA) and Their Recent (2026) Victories in Local Elections and Congressional Primaries?

Zhihu

1. A Brief View of This Political Group

The DSA is internally divided into many factions, but on the whole it still belongs to the social-democratic reformist tradition: at home, it supports unions, free health care, free education and childcare, raising the minimum wage, cutting the cost of living such as rent, and keeping big money out of elections; abroad, it opposes hegemony and opposes Israel's genocide in Gaza. The DSA's attitude toward China is rather complex: some factions are very favourable to the Chinese model and oppose Trump's trade war against China, while others remain critical of China's authoritarian model and its capitalist turn. The DSA pays relatively little attention to China; on the whole it is one of the main political forces in America with a fairly good attitude toward China.

2. Analysing the Factors Behind This Round of Victories

The DSA's candidates in this round of elections have won consecutively in New York and Colorado, several of them against old politicians who had been in office for many consecutive years. The mainstream American media have already widely discussed the rise of socialism nationwide, comparing it with the rise of the Tea Party within the Republican Party.

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Why Zohran Mamdani's big night as the Democratic party's new kingmaker matters for every Fortune 500 CEO in every city and state



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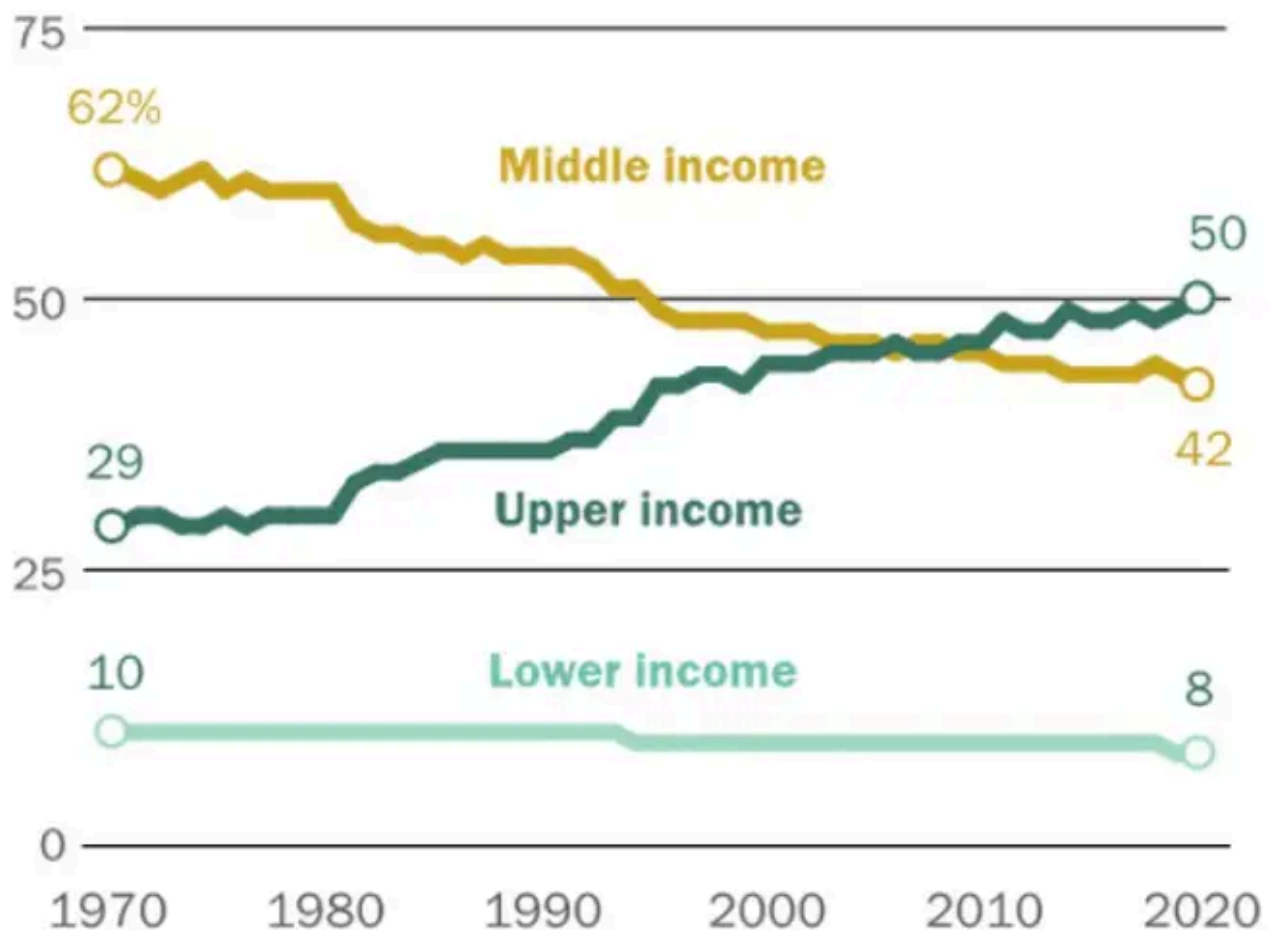


NYC Mayor Zohran Mamdani made three endorsements as head of the Democratic party, with two defeating incumbents.
MICHAEL M. SANTIAGO/GETTY IMAGES

In fact, since the first global crisis of the neoliberal wave in 2008, the polarisation of American society has been very evident. According to survey data^{[\[1\]](#)}, since the Reagan revolution of 1980 the income share of the American middle-income group has kept falling while that of high earners has kept rising. This trend continued after the 2008 financial crisis, and today, the income share of high earners has surpassed the sum of the middle- and low-income earners.

Share of aggregate income held by U.S. middle class has plunged since 1970

% of U.S. aggregate household income held by lower-, middle- and upper-income households



Note: Households are assigned to income tiers based on their size-adjusted income in the calendar year prior to the survey year. Their unadjusted incomes are then totaled to compute the share of U.S. aggregate household income held by each income tier. Shares may not add to 100% due to rounding.

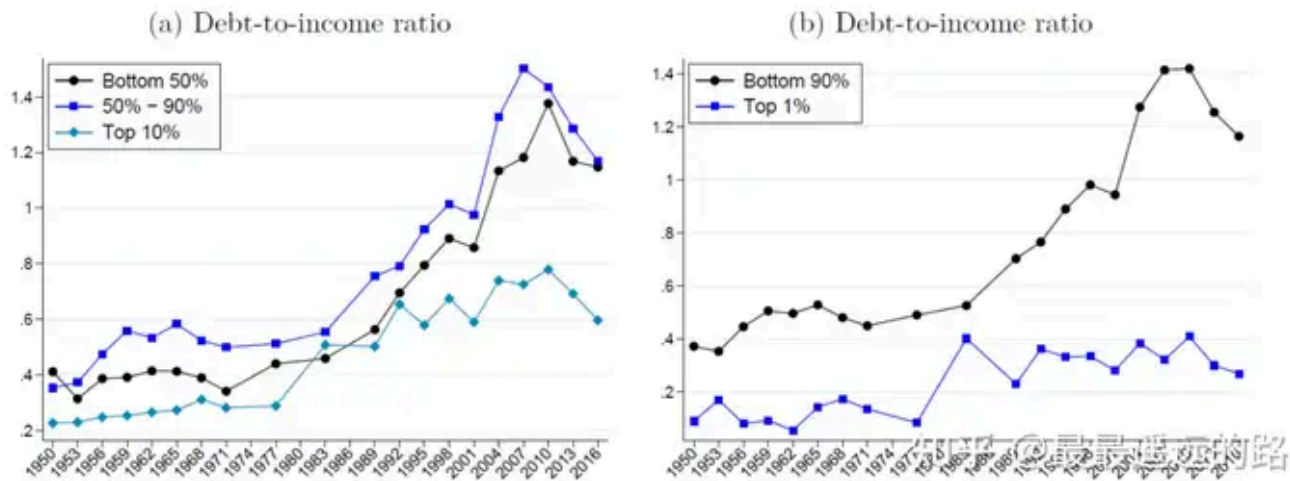
Source: Pew Research Center analysis of the Current Population Survey, Annual Social and Economic Supplement (IPUMS).

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Before the 2008 crisis, middle- and low-income Americans could still maintain their living standards by going into debt^[2], so the truth of society-wide polarisation could still be temporarily concealed. But after the financial crisis, the impoverishment of middle- and low-income earners has become an unavoidable social reality.

Figure 2: Debt-to-income ratios across the income distribution



As shown above, after 1980 the debt-to-income ratios of all classes in American society increased, but the rise among middle- and low-income earners was clearly greater than among high earners. Especially after 2001, the debt ratio of middle- and low-income earners rose rapidly, while high earners changed little.

The first to react in American society were the working masses. Through the Occupy Wall Street movement they expressed their anger that the government had rescued the banks but not the people. The Occupy movement's approval among Democrats and centrist voters was higher than the Tea Party's^[3]. This shows that this movement against Wall Street big capital did indeed express what the American masses felt.

More Independents Support Occupy Wall St. than Tea Party

<i>Occupy Wall St. movement</i>	Total	Rep	Dem	Ind
	%	%	%	%
Support	39	19	52	43
Oppose	35	55	25	35
Neither/DK	<u>26</u>	<u>25</u>	<u>22</u>	<u>22</u>
	100	100	100	100

<i>Tea Party movement</i>				
Support	32	63	13	30
Oppose	44	20	64	49
Neither/DK	<u>25</u>	<u>17</u>	<u>23</u>	<u>21</u>
	100	100	100	100

PEW RESEARCH CENTER/WASHINGTON POST Oct. 20-23, 2011. Figures may not add to 100% because of rounding.

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However, this movement merely expressed anger, hoping the politicians would listen to their voices; it had no strategy of independent struggle, and naturally came to nothing. After Occupy, Obama solved no real problem; the reform proposals he offered were so weak that they could neither activate the left nor avoid enraging the right. Political polarisation showed itself in the 2015 primaries. The Republican Trump and the Democrat Sanders both started with low approval, but because their views were more "extreme" than the establishment's, they won the voters' favour and their support kept climbing. The Democratic Party's central apparatus did everything to stop Sanders, while the Republicans' internal democracy was greater and could not stop Trump. The final result: Trump won the election for the Republicans.

Trump's Republican Party really had only one policy: shift domestic contradictions abroad — concretely, trade war and tech war against China. But as we have repeatedly analysed (see: *The Rise and Fall of the Capitalist World-System (II): The Internal Structure of Transnational Production Capitalism*, and "What does Trump's repost that the real enemies are the UN and NATO, not China and Russia, mean?"), in the era of transnational production capitalism, America's production depends entirely on China; it is utterly incapable of waging war. In the end, Trump tried to use force against other anti-American forces that echoed China, but came to grief in Persia (Iran) (see: "The Iranian delegation has arrived in Islamabad; Trump says the next 24 hours will be a key window — what are the prospects for US-Iran talks?").

After the Republican Party's failure to shift contradictions abroad, the domestic contradictions burst out in full. As shown below^[4], the trajectory of personal financial conditions reveals that, after 2000, America went through three periods of sharply intensified economic contradiction. The first was the 2008 financial crisis; the second was the COVID-19 pandemic of 2020; the third is the cost-of-living crisis caused by Trump's tariff war and the Persian (Iran) war.

The impoverishment of the working masses necessarily brings the rise of the left. As shown below^[5], 66% of Democratic Party voters support socialism.

Even more startling: among American adults under 30, 34% say they like communism^[6], while supporters of socialism in the broad sense already exceed 60%^[7]. The revival of left-wing politics in America is the expression of the growing radicalisation of the increasingly impoverished masses.

On international questions, the American masses can bear Israel's genocide in Gaza less and less. Polls show that 60% of American adults hold a negative view of Israel and its leaders^[8].

And six in ten American adults also oppose the Persian (Iran) war^[9].

In such circumstances, it is no surprise that a wave of socialists has arisen within the Democratic Party. As Zolan said in his speech after the candidate he supported won: his own victory last year was no accident. His victory is not the end, but the beginning of a larger movement. In a word: the big part is still ahead.

3. Predicting the Prospects of This Movement

In 2016, between reformist left politics and nationalist right politics, the American masses chose the right, for various reasons. After a full decade of floundering, the empire's narrative and nationalist narrative of the right are nearly in ruins. The declining empire no longer has the capacity to shift contradictions outward. The trade war cannot be won, the tech war cannot be won, the supply-chain war even less, and in the end the hot war ended in utter defeat. In such circumstances, the whole

society inevitably turns inward and faces its internal contradictions directly. This can be seen from the masses' extreme disgust at the huge military aid to Israel. The masses, mired in economic distress, have grown weary of this imperial rivalry.

It is against this background that Zolan and a large number of DSA members have been elected to representative bodies at all levels. This is very likely the beginning of the comprehensive socialisation of American society.

In the era of national industrial capitalism, America, by virtue of its industrial hegemony, was not remade by social democracy as the West European countries were. As the world moves toward multipolarity and China and the other emerging powers rise, America's hegemony has been terminated. An empire that has lost its hegemony and does not want to fall into revolution must take the reformist road. For capital, reform is always better than revolution — after all, reform does not directly abolish the capitalist system. Hence it is foreseeable that, for a long time to come, socialist and progressive forces like the DSA will experience a slow but steady rise, easing domestic contradictions through the gradual introduction of free health care, free education, and other reform measures.

The DSA and its allied progressive forces are likely to transform the Democratic Party. The DSA as the party's left wing, with the progressives between the DSA and the establishment (like Warren) as the centre, would leave the old establishment a right-wing minority. The grassroots centre-left may well gain the dominant position. If the Democrats come to power, they will likely push through reform policies at home — free universal health care, raising the minimum wage. A reformist economy cannot compete with economies of low labour rights; even setting aside political antagonism, on purely economic grounds China would have to be excluded. Hence, in foreign relations, America would very likely join the CPTPP, uniting Europe and Japan to build a trade bloc shutting China out.

On the basis of the present state of the world, reformism can still be counted as a progressive force. America is, after all, a great power — large in size and great in worldwide influence. An America remade by reformism would, on the one hand, be relatively more inclined to peace in international relations; and for the working people of the globe, raising labour-rights standards and pushing labour protection at the global level is definitely a good thing.

By the 2040s, as Southeast Asia and South Asia reach or approach the Lewis turning point, trade-union movements and reformist politics will rise there step by step as well. At that time, a reformist wave may well appear across the globe. The rise of the DSA in America is very likely the historical precursor of global left-wing reformism.

Notes

[1] "How the American middle class has changed in the past five decades" (Pew Research Center)

中文原文: How the American middle class has changed in the past five decades

<https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2022/04/20/how-the-american-middle-class-has-changed-in-the-past-five-decades/>

[2] "Modigliani Meets Minsky: Inequality and U.S. Household Debt Since 1950" (Institute for New Economic Thinking)

中文原文: Modigliani Meets Minsky: Inequality and U.S. Household Debt Since 1950

https://www.ineteconomics.org/perspectives/blog/modigliani-meets-minsky-inequality-and-u-s-household-debt-since-1950?__cf_chl_f_tk=t8yCZ5gqV5opvpK45z5BGMbASAU62WhsxQREvprBUuI-1783231243-1.0.1.1-1fx8IBV2ypK4yRNIPKAvMrP7VjjfjE8gs_ew7S.RbL8o

[3] "Public Divided Over Occupy Wall Street Movement" (Pew Research Center)

中文原文: Public Divided Over Occupy Wall Street Movement

<https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2011/10/24/public-divided-over-occupy-wall-street-movement/>

[4] "Image of Capitalism Slips to 54% in U.S." (Gallup)

中文原文: Image of Capitalism Slips to 54% in U.S.

<https://news.gallup.com/poll/694835/image-capitalism-slips.aspx>

[5] "Image of Capitalism Slips to 54% in U.S." (Gallup)

中文原文: Image of Capitalism Slips to 54% in U.S.

<https://news.gallup.com/poll/694835/image-capitalism-slips.aspx>

[6] "Young Americans Like Socialism Too Much — That's a Problem Libertarians Must Fix" (Cato Institute)

中文原文: Young Americans Like Socialism Too Much—That's a Problem Libertarians Must Fix

<https://www.cato.org/blog/young-americans-socialism-too-much-thats-problem-libertarians-must-fix>

[7] "Survey: Nearly two-thirds of young Americans support socialism" (Campus Reform)

中文原文: Survey: Nearly two-thirds of young Americans support socialism

<https://www.campusreform.org/article/survey-nearly-two-thirds-young-americans-support-socialism/28114>

[8] "Negative views of Israel, Netanyahu continue to rise among Americans — especially young people" (Pew Research Center)

中文原文: Negative views of Israel, Netanyahu continue to rise among Americans — especially young people

<https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2026/04/07/negative-views-of-israel-netanyahu-continue-to-rise-among-americans-especially-young-people/>

[9] "Americans Broadly Disapprove of U.S. Military Action in Iran: Wide partisan gap in expectations for how long the conflict will last" (Pew Research Center)

中文原文: Americans Broadly Disapprove of U.S. Military Action in Iran Wide partisan gap in expectations for how long the conflict will last

<https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2026/03/25/americans-broadly-disapprove-of-u-s-military-action-in-iran/>

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